

# BASIC SKILLS OF COMMUNICATION

LISTENING, READING, NON-VERBAL SKILLS.

# Basic Skills – Definition

- Skills in communication are practical ways of sending and receiving messages cultivated over the years.
- Basic skills are the most important and the most necessary because all other skills are based on them.
- They constitute the starting point before the addition of extras.
- They are the fundamental skills of communication.
- These skills are Listening, Speaking, Reading, Writing and Non-verbal skills.

# Basic Skills

- Listening and Reading are receptive skills while Speaking and Writing are Expressive skills.
- We spend 75% of our waking life in communication.
- 42% in Listening.
- 32% in Speaking.
- 15% in Reading.
- 11% in Writing.

# LISTENING - QUOTATIONS

- He who has ears to hear, let him hear.
- My beloved brethren, let every man be swift to hear (listen), slow to speak, slow to anger.
- The reason why we have two ears and only one mouth is that we may listen the more and talk less. (Zeno)
- Give every man the ear but few thy voice.
- It is the province of knowledge to speak and it is the privilege of wisdom to listen. (Oliver Wendell Holmes)
- The ILA is the scholarly organization devoted to the study and teaching of listening behaviours. [www.listen.org](http://www.listen.org).

# MISCONCEPTIONS ABOUT LISTENING

- Listening and hearing are synonymous.
- Listening competence develops naturally and so there is no need for systematic training.
- Listening is primarily a passive activity.
- Effective communication is the responsibility of the speaker
- Listening means agreement or obedience.

# THE IMPORTANCE OF LISTENING

- It is the most basic skill of language development.
- It is the main channel classroom instruction. Much of what we know comes from listening
- It is the most used language skill
- Effective listening is rewarding
- It can make us critical of the thousands of messages we receive everyday.
- Listening influences our personal development and information management.

# TYPES OF LISTENING

- Appreciative Listening: This is listening for enjoyment. It is highly individualized and the most basic form of listening.
- Informational Listening: Listening to understand the message and to retain it for future use. Much of our educational process depends on this type of listening.
- Critical or Evaluative Listening: This is when we listen to understand, to analyse and to evaluate messages. Persuasive messages have three components: speaker credibility, logical argumentation and psychological appeal.
- Therapeutic or Empathic Listening: Listening to provide a troubled speaker the opportunity to talk about his problem.

# POOR LISTENING HABITS

- Faking attention: Pretending to listen.
- Listening only for facts: We are so much in a hurry that we want to hear only the bare essentials.
- Avoiding difficult material: We normally turn off listening to material we find difficult to understand.
- Avoiding the uninteresting: We often equate value and entertainment. Our TV culture has facilitated this.
- Criticizing the speaker: We are often concerned with who a speaker is and how he speaks.

# Poor Listening Habits.

- Yielding to distractions: Distraction is the divided attention from the chosen object of attention. Causes: inattention, lack of interest, novelty or attractiveness of objects, variety.
- Physical Distraction: Automatic attention. When a person walks into a room. Perceived danger, discomfort, tiredness.
- Mental distractions: Daydreaming, semantic and grammatical distractions.
- Defensive Listening: We normally select what we want to hear.

# Poor Listening Habits.

- Self-centred Listening: The arrogance of thinking that we already know what is going to be said.
- Our thinking speaking rate.
- Message Overload: The brain shuts down after constant bombardment of information.
- Our Short Attention Span: The amount of time we concentrate on a task without getting distracted. Our attention span is crucial for the achievement of our goals.

# IMPROVING LISTENING SKILLS

- We need listening role models: Parents, friends, teachers, pastors, police officers, doctors etc.
- Vary the way you listen to suit various situations.
- Be attentive and resist all distractions, especially mental distractions.
- Develop interest in what other people say. You get new information. It helps organizational culture if the boss is a good listener

# Improving Listening Skills.

- Be patient and hold yourself back from interrupting. Do not think of your reply when listening. Do not jump to conclusions.
- Do active listening. Maintain eye contact. Take notes. Give acknowledgement responses
- Give a feedback. Check and confirm dates, times, places of meeting, roles.

# READING SKILLS

- Reading is decoding or interpreting written symbols. The ultimate purpose is to understand the message.
- The International Reading Association provides information about the organization and its efforts to provide literacy throughout the world.
- The web address is [www.reading.org](http://www.reading.org)

# TYPES OF READING

- Scanning: Look through or read something quickly. We scan for names in an article or words in a dictionary.
- Skimming is used to quickly identify the main ideas in a text. Normally we read the first and last lines of a passage.
- Extensive Reading: When a person reads large amounts of high-interest material usually for pleasure and for facts in current affairs.
- Intensive Reading: It is the detailed analysis of information, vocabulary and grammar in a book or a passage.

# USES OF READING

- Reading helps us to acquire skills for life-long learning. Further education depends on reading. Professional competence depends on reading.
- Reading exposes people to the accumulated wisdom of human civilization.
- It improves our spoken and written language. It improves our vocabulary, spelling and grammar. Reading exposes us to the imaginative use of words.
- Reading is a basic skill to which we can add other literacies like computer, financial and media literacies.

# Uses of Reading

- Our ability to read has economic consequences. Higher levels of literacy are required in business, industry and agriculture.
- The healthy development of individuals and societies depend on reading. Better nutrition, mothering and health depend on reading.
- Reading is crucial in our research and finding relevant information.
- Reading exercises the brain much better than watching films on TV.
- Reading broadens our horizon introducing us to other cultures and places of the world.

# Uses of Reading

- It improves our concentration, discipline, creativity, focus and memory.
- It builds self-esteem and gives you new things to talk about.
- Reading reduces boredom.

# PROBLEMS OF READING

- There are general problems of comprehension. Michael West and vocabulary levels.
- The death of the Reading Culture in Ghana. There are so many interesting competitors
- Dyslexia: A medical condition which makes it difficult for some people to read.
- Symptoms: word reversals in reading and writing, problems of directionality, poor handwriting or printing, comprehension and difficulty writing down what they have read.

# Problems of Reading

- Ineffective instruction in reading.
- The problem of vocalization and subvocalization.
- Reading: Going back to read the same line.
- Deterioration in our reading levels due to lack of practice.
- Functional Illiteracy: The inability to read, write and calculate well enough to function properly in society. Our inability and unwillingness to read and understand simple written instructions. Our inability to fill simple forms.

# IMPROVING READING

- Do a lot of extensive reading. Read novels, magazines, journals and newspapers.
- Do intensive reading. Study technical texts. Consider short passages. It may be a memorable description, philosophy or an opinion powerfully expressed.
- Develop the skill of fast reading. Deal with vocalization and subvocalization. Google 25,000 words a minute.

# NON-VERBAL SKILLS

- This is communication without the use of words. It may or may not accompany speech. It is difficult to study because it is not structured. It has no book or dictionary.
- Forms of non-verbal communication vary from culture to culture and can easily be misunderstood.
- Gestures: Signs made with various parts of the body – the head, the hands.
- Postures: The way we hold our body seated or standing. Some postures show confidence, attention and interest. Others show boredom, tiredness and lack of interest.

# Non-Verbal Skills.

- Eye contact: Some people see eye contact as a sign of honesty. Others see it as rude.
- Touching behavior: it conveys warmth, comfort and friendliness. Various forms of body contact have their meanings.
- Use of Space: The size, placement and privacy of one's office show status.
- The use of time: Punctuality and African time.
- The use of colour.